demonstrations. Israel will be poorer over the next few years and its vibrant economy will be a thing of the past; some of its technological experts will leave the country, as will some of its most impressive high-tech companies; the level of its education will go down and elements of its cultural life will have to move to underground (for example, to samizdat).

This is not the worse of it. Religious influence will weigh on life and leisure: public transport on Shabbat will be limited, possibly abolished, and who knows what else will not be allowed. The tech specialists who leave will be followed by part of the scientific and artistic elites, by some of the best medical practitioners, and, more generally, by those able to find a better way of life outside the country.

If this trend is not reversed at the next elections, if this nationalist and aggressive political alliance stays in power, the question of who will defend the country will soon have to be faced. The ultra-Orthodox will do everything to avoid service in the army; the question is whether, in a country under their growing dominance, the secular and liberal part of the population will show much enthusiasm for carrying that heavy burden alone.

Wednesday, May 24

This morning, a few hours after the budget passed, Netanyahu declared that the judicial overhaul could be considered again. Shortly afterwards he declared that he believed a compromise could be achieved. What should we conclude? Are the compromise negotiations gone with the wind? Or is the first declaration just one more maneuver to avoid a split within the Likud? It won’t take very long to tell.

Thursday, May 25